

Adoption of Mobile Banking Services
Among Rural and Urban Populations in
Sri Lanka

Table of Contents

1. Introduction	1
1.1 Background of the Study.....	1
1.2 Motivation and Rationale for the Research	1
1.3 Research Questions and Objectives.....	1
1.4 Scope and Significance of the Study	2
2. Literature Review	2
2.2 Challenges and Ethical Considerations in Mobile Banking.....	3
2.3 Gaps in Existing Knowledge	3
2.4 Theoretical Framework	3
3. Methodology.....	4
3.1 Research Approach and Justification	4
3.2 Mixed Methods Strategy: Surveys and Interviews	4
3.3 Research Design and Sampling	4
3.4 Data Collection Techniques	5
3.5 Data Analysis Procedures	5
3.6 Ethical Considerations	5
4. Results and Discussion	5
4.1.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents	6
4.1.2 Mobile Banking Usage Patterns	7
4.1.3 Perceptions and Challenges	8
4.2 Interview Insights.....	10
4.3 Comparative Analysis: Rural vs. Urban Findings	11
4.4 Summary of Key Findings	11
5. Discussion of Challenges and Limitations	12
5.1 Research Limitations.....	12
5.2 Operational and Fieldwork Challenges	12
5.3 Validity and Reliability Concerns	12
6. Conclusions and Recommendations.....	13
6.1 Summary of Key Outcomes	13
6.2 Policy and Practical Implications	13
6.3 Recommendations for Stakeholders	13
6.4 Suggestions for Future Research.....	13
References	14
References	14

Appendices	15
Appendix A – Survey Questionnaire.....	15
Appendix B – Interview Questions	17
Appendix – Interview scripts	18

1. Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

The banking industry worldwide has been transformed because of the fast growth of mobile technology. In Sri Lanka, mobile banking operations have gained popularity particularly in urban regions where internet and smartphone penetration are at a high rate. Successful adoption in rural communities is however hampered by challenges of less digital literacy, poor infrastructure and lack of awareness. As the field of mobile banking becomes the national priority in respects of this work is based on the consideration of the discrepancy in the rates of this adoption between the rural and urban population and its overall economic growth and equity (Chen, 2022).

1.2 Motivation and Rationale for the Research

This study is due to the rising sensation of the digital gap between the rural and urban people in Sri Lanka. Although mobile banking is likely to enhance accessibility in the financial sector, its literature. The present research will address that gap by giving data-oriented conclusions that can be used to formulate specific strategies and policies. The objective is to enable the equal access to financial services and empower disadvantaged groups (Suri, 2016).

1.3 Research Questions and Objectives

Research Questions

Objective 1: To compare the adoption rates of mobile banking services between rural and urban populations in Sri Lanka.

Objective 2: To identify the key factors influencing mobile banking adoption in both demographic segments.

Objective 3: To assess the challenges faced by rural populations in accessing and using mobile banking services.

Objective 4: To propose strategies to improve mobile banking penetration in rural Sri Lanka.

Research Objectives

1. What is the current rate of mobile banking adoption among rural users compared to urban users in Sri Lanka?

2. What socioeconomic, technological, and perceptual factors influence the adoption of mobile banking in rural and urban areas?
3. What are the major barriers (e.g., digital literacy, connectivity, trust, usability) preventing rural users from adopting mobile banking?
4. What interventions or policy recommendations could enhance mobile banking adoption among rural communities in Sri Lanka?

1.4 Scope and Significance of the Study

This study will cover both mobile banking users and non-users in both the rural and urban regions of Sri Lanka and this will retrieve the data via survey and interviews. These factors are demographic, technological and perceptual factors in the banking mobile behavior. It is important because it enables the stakeholders involved including banks, policymakers, and technology developers to know how to customize the services to fit various needs. The study documents influential barriers and drivers, which will help the country to achieve its objectives of financial inclusion. The study intentionally hopes to contribute to a more inclusive digitalized financial system that can be enjoyed by all the nationals (Zhou, 2023).

2. Literature Review

2.1 Overview of Mobile Banking in Sri Lanka

The developed innovation of mobile banking in the Sri Lankan context is a crucial tool in the financial service industry, offering easy, cheap accessibility to financial transactions using mobile adoption is, however, not that high. The World Bank (2023) points out that although financial inclusion levels have improved in many respects, the rural population is experiencing challenges regarding the access to digital financial instruments. Still hampering uptake are factors like poor infrastructure, low digital literacy and language barriers. Researchers have demonstrated that cultural perceptions and their trust in technology influence user behavior (study by Perera and Fernando, 2021). In an attempt to narrow this gap, the Central Bank of Sri Lanka and other financial institutions are increasingly promoting services, based on the use of mobiles, that can help them achieve this goal in the light of the enhanced capacity of mobile-banking to positively influence formal financial inclusion. Nonetheless, the differences still exist in such dimensions as awareness, access, and usage due to the regions. What this requires

is an investigation into more detail into the mobile banking ecosystem both in urban and rural so as to come up with more fair solutions (Suri, 2016).

2.2 Challenges and Ethical Considerations in Mobile Banking

There are several obstacles to the introduction of a mobile bank in Sri Lanka at least, in rural areas. Rural users can easily be unable to use the services on a regular basis due to such technical conditions as poor network connections, less physical access to smartphones, and the insufficient electricity supply. Moreover, the absence of digital literacy and mobile banking application training also contributes to an increase in a gap in terms of use. Trust remains a major as possible exploitation by financial institutions. The best way to break these barriers is through ensuring that mobile bank applications are multi lingual, user friendly and safe. User-centered design should be a priority point among policymakers and developers to educate everyone about the usage of the technologies to empower the vulnerable and disadvantaged population groups. These ethical and operational issues are needed to be addressed in order to develop a trustful, inclusive mobile banking environment (Davis, 1989).

2.3 Gaps in Existing Knowledge

Despite much research on the topic of mobile banking uptake being done in other parts of the world, there is observable lack of evidence in terms of region-specific studies associating to the country of Sri Lanka and especially to the rural citizenry. Most of the available literature mainly deals. The other gap is in longitudinal studies with duration that follows a trend over time and assesses the effect of any governmental or institutional intervention. In addition to that, most studies consider either the qualitative or the quantitative side hence lacking a holistic view of user behavior. This disparity is especially inadequate in developing such inclusive policies or establishing mobile banking applications that are user-friendly. The absence of research that uses mixed methods focusing on the rural areas introduces a big potential of originality that the study will be able to provide in offering valuable thoughts that would spur meaningful transformation in financing inclusion initiatives to various regions in Sri Lanka (Chen, 2022).

2.4 Theoretical Framework

The current study uses the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the aspect of the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT) to streamline the adoption of mobile banking in Sri Lanka. According to the TAM perceived usefulness and ease of use are major determinants of technology adoption. In relation to mobile banking, these aspects determine

how people especially in the rural set up have the confidence to transact their businesses using the digital platforms, trusted peers or institutions coupled by the existence of viable infrastructure to support the same. These models are suitable since in them, it is possible to evaluate not only individual attitudes but also external factors of influence. They also take into consideration the cultural and technological hurdles that exist in most of the developing nations. The retail will apply TAM and UTAUT to not only help design survey questionnaires and interview topics but also to explain the behavior of users in the two different environments. Through the models, the study hopes to bring in a structured idea about what motivates and what deters the mobiles banking uptake in Sri Lanka (Perera, 2021).

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Approach and Justification

The study is resourceful at the mixed-methods since it involves both the quantitative and qualitative methods to study mobile banking adoption in both rural and urban regions in Sri Lanka. A combination of two of them is warranted because a mixed approach allows collecting general statistics and gathering details at the same time. The quantitative information provides quantitative comparisons between groups of people whereas the qualitative input helps to interpret perceptions and difficulties. This strategy will result in a broader perception of user activity and contextual barriers. With all the complexities of mobile banking adoption induced by the contribution of socioeconomic, cultural and technological factors there is variability in the reliability and relevance of findings and therefore application of both methods enables the findings to be conclusive.

3.2 Mixed Methods Strategy: Surveys and Interviews

The study uses a mixed-methods approach where it involves both quantitative data collection in a survey of 50 people and the use of qualitative interviews consisting of 3 participants who were selected, thus increasing the validity of the results. The interviews may provide the context to generalizable trends found by the survey. The approach will allow breadth and depth of knowledge on mobile banking use among different categories of users.

3.3 Research Design and Sampling

The study employs the cross-sectional research design in a comparative study to determine the extent of current mobile bank utilization among the rural and urban citizens. Purposive sampling technique is used to make it represent both of the demographic groups. The section

of 78 survey participants (25 rural, 25 urban) is chosen to have balanced view. As a complement, 3 respondents with different mobile banking experiences are selected to benefit in-depth interviews, which pay special attention to rural problems. The sample is reasonable in terms of exploratory research and it offers a feasible scope both in terms of time and resources. This design is able to support direct comparison between the two levels of population.

3.4 Data Collection Techniques

Both the structured surveys and semi-structured interviews will be used in data collection. The survey questionnaire, which was created using Google Forms, will include multiple-choice questions and short- experiences, difficulties and suggestions of any improvement. The tools are both tested out to be clear and effective. The dual methodology provides extensive data that can be used in the comparison of data statistically and even in narrative characteristics of mobile banking activities.

3.5 Data Analysis Procedures

The use of descriptive statistics via software like Excel or SPSS will be utilized to investigate the results to the survey with the ability to compare the trends of usage, demographic, and challenge data between rural and urban respondents. Key differences in the adoption patterns will be identified using frequencies, percentages and cross- tabulations. With respect to the qualitative, the qualitative ones will offer a more comprehensive view, which will ultimately allow formulating viable, evidence-informed recommendations on how mobile banking can become more acceptable in the population.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

Ethics is upheld through the study process. Prior to the participation in a survey or interview, participants are aware of the purpose of the study in which informed consent is presented. Confidentiality and anonymity have been guaranteed by the use of codes to receive data about the participants as well as storage of all the answers in a secure manner. The involvement is not mandatory, and an individual has a right to stop without any implications. There is special treatment whenever communicating with the rural subjects so as to guarantee clear, respectful and non-elitist communication. The concerned academic body will grant ethical clearance to the concerned academic body and all the activities will be carried to the institutional and international ethical guidelines of research of human-subjects.

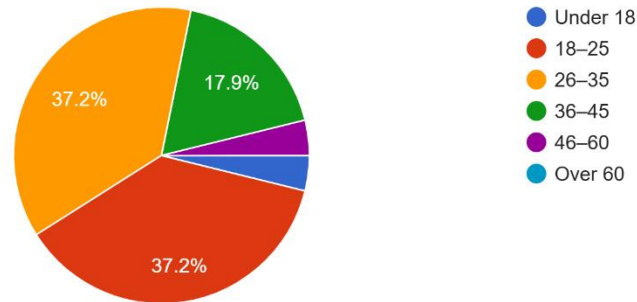
4. Results and Discussion

4.1 Survey Findings

4.1.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents

What is your age?

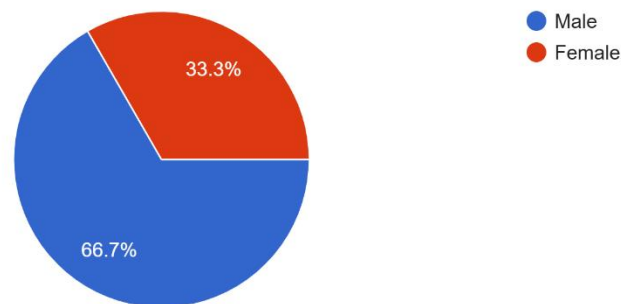
78 responses



The pie chart will demonstrate the representation of the age of 78 respondents to the survey of mobile banking. They lie mostly on 1825 and 2635 age bracket, with 37.2 percent of the respondents respectively. The age bracket of 36 45, 46 60, and Over 60 is also less represented thus indicating that the use of mobile banking is more common among the younger adults.

What is your gender?

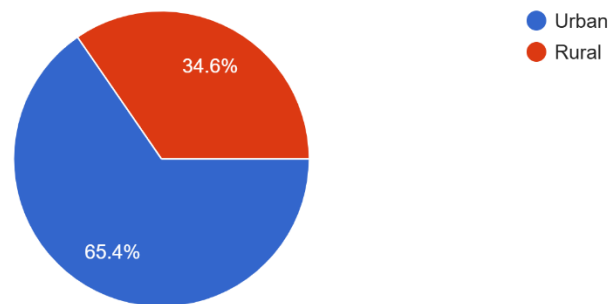
78 responses



As captured in the chart, a total of 78 respondents were used with 66.7 percent composed of males and 33.3 percent females. This shows a gender disparity where the number of male respondents in the survey of mobile banking is two times more than the female. It implies that more men use mobile banking or were more prone to the survey.

What is your location?

78 responses

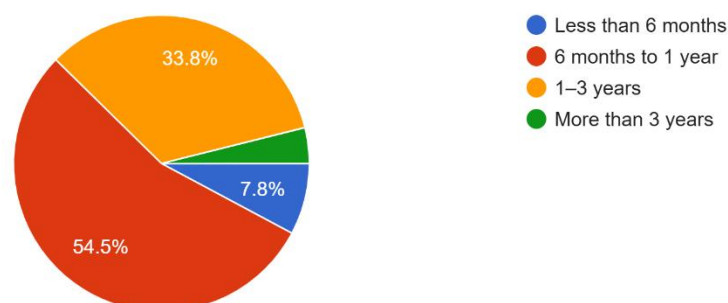


The pie chart shows that 65.4 percent of the respondents are representing urban people, whereas 34.6 percent of the citizens are rural. This implies that there is a more significant urban representation of survey participants, which can be associated with more availability in digital platforms and mobile banking. The information helps in the purpose of the study which is to compare the adoption rate between the two population groups.

4.1.2 Mobile Banking Usage Patterns

How long have you been using mobile banking?

77 responses

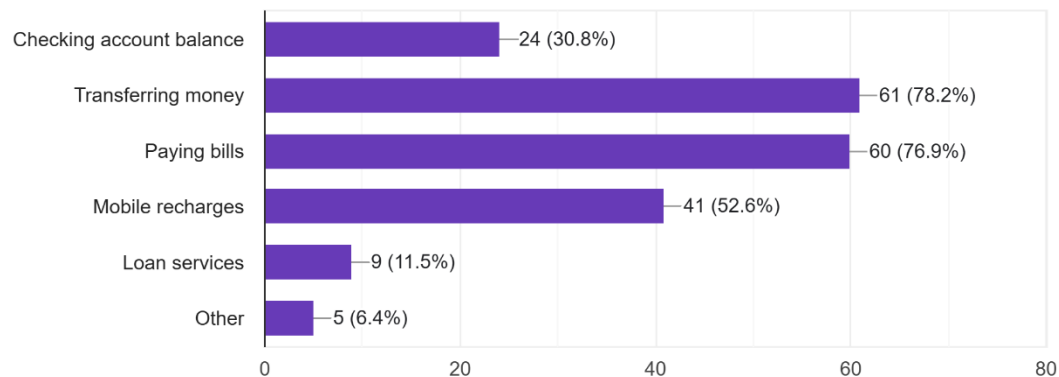


The chart shows that mobile banking has grown significantly in recent times with 54.5 percent using the service between 6 months and 1 year, 33.8 percent using it between 1 and 3 years and only 7.8 percent are new users (less than 6 months) with a very small percentage using it in

over 3 years. This implies that mobile banking is novel in the sense that most people have experienced it only recently and within the last year, it has been increasingly adopted.

Which mobile banking services do you use?

78 responses

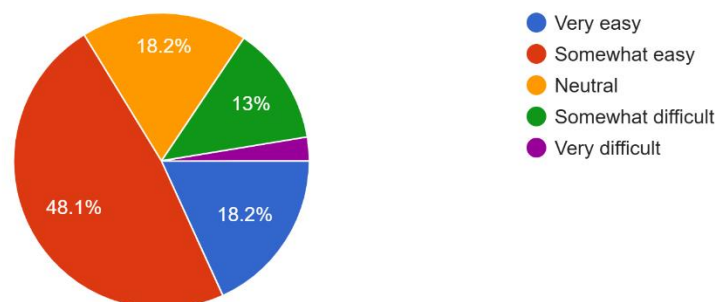


It was found that the most popular mobile banking services used by the respondents are money transfer (78.2%) and bills payment (76.9%), according to the bar chart. Mobile recharges follow with (52.6%), and checking of account balances is done less at 30.8 percent. Only a small portion of 11.6 percent resp. 6.4 percent feel used other services resp. utilised loan services. This implies that mobile banking users primarily use it to do basic transactions, and not complex financial services.

4.1.3 Perceptions and Challenges

How easy is it for you to use mobile banking apps?

77 responses

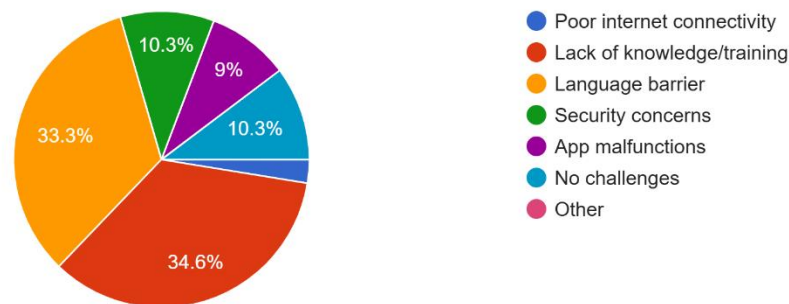


As the chart indicates, 48.1 percent of study participants opine mobile banking applications as becoming fairly easy with the next 18.2 percent voting as very easy. 13 percent described it as being somewhat difficult, whereas only 1.3 percent (1 person) found it very difficult. In the

meantime, 18.2 percent sided with being neutral. All in all, the statistics indicate that most users believe that mobile banking apps are quite easy to navigate, but a small segment of users struggles with the issue of usability.

Have you ever faced any challenges using mobile banking?

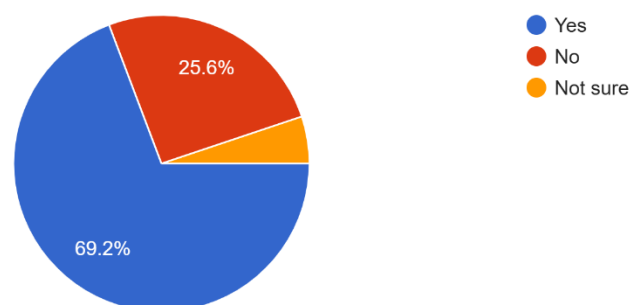
78 responses



As depicted in the chart, the least knowledgeable or trained (34.6%) and the language barrier (33.3%) are the most frequently cited problems experienced by any mobile banking user. The other emerging faults are the security issues (10.3 %), bad internet connection (10.3%), and the app failure (9%). It shows that better user education and app accessibility should be implemented, including non-English-speaking or potentially inexperienced online users. These are some of the obstacles that need to be addressed in order to enhance adoption particularly in the rural regions.

Do you feel mobile banking is secure?

78 responses

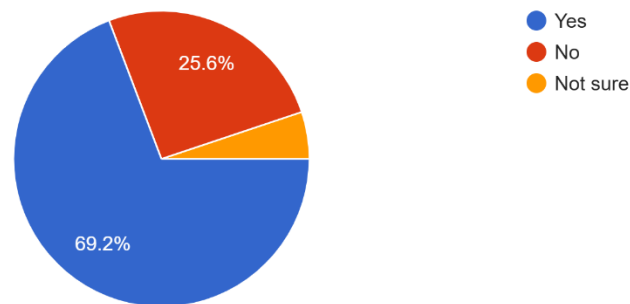


The chart indicates that 69.2 percent of the respondent answers that mobile banking is secure and 25.6 percent answers that mobile banking is not secure and 5.1 percent are undecided. This

shows that there is a relatively high trust factor in mobile banking applications among the users, although it also goes to show that more than a quarter of the participants acknowledge security to be an issue that still has to be dealt with by banks and developers based on reinforcement and awareness measures, enhanced authentication and user education.

Do you feel mobile banking is secure?

78 responses



This pie chart indicates that 69.2 percent of respondents believe that mobile banking is safe, which demonstrates high confidence among the users of online financial services. Nevertheless, no less than 25.6 per cent do not consider it to be safe and 5.1 per cent are not sure that it is, which means that quite a significant number of users continue to doubt or misunderstand. Such fears are either related to previous experience or cybersecurity knowledge or fear of fraud, so it is important that user awareness be raised and better security protection in apps.

4.2 Interview Insights

Thematic analysis of the three participants was carried out and the following themes are identified, namely, accessibility barriers, digital literacy and usability, and trust and security perceptions.

Rural users often referred to accessibility barriers, often in terms of infrastructure. A respondent said, “There are occasions when the application will not load due to bad signal strength, especially in the rural communities.” And here is the element of a network instable in rural locations. One more added, that the nearest bank facility was at 10 kilometers away, and so I use mobile banking but it does not work all the time.

The digital literacy and usability issues were particularly prominent in older ones. One of the rural respondents said, “I find it difficult to get some terms in English in this app,” which means

local language should be supported. One of them added, My daughter taught me but I still press the ones that I am not supposed to. These remarks indicate that online learning and design levels are lacking.

Concerning faithfulness and protection, the urban users had a higher level of confidence. One IT professional responded, I trust mobile banking due to a two-factor authentication. On the other hand, during the poll of a rural respondent, he owned up: I am concerned that I could lose money in the event of a mistake or in case of a hack.

These qualitative insights support the research results and emphasize the value of intervention personalization, including the employment of local apps, the user interface easier to interact with, and the use of communities in the context of online training.

4.3 Comparative Analysis: Rural vs. Urban Findings

The presented analysis indicates that differences in mobile banking uptake among rural and urban respondents are rather different. The general tendency was that urban users experience the frequency of usage, improvement in digital literacy, and confidence in the security of mobile banking. They usually called the apps convenient and easy to use. In comparison, the rural users were more disadvantaged, having low access to internet, language barrier, and limited knowledge of technology. One of the interviewees in the rural areas commented; I cannot use it without the assistance of my daughter. The urban respondents were confident and one of them said, I use it every day and it is very safe. These analogies has a clear digital divide.

4.4 Summary of Key Findings

The research finds significant differences between the rural and urban residents of Sri Lanka in terms of mobile banking application. The urban users have a high rate of adoption, frequent usage, and confidence on the security and functionality of the apps. On the other hand, barriers such as unreliable internet connection, inability to read and write as well as language challenges are major barriers to rural users. Though the majority of the respondents recognize mobile banking as a service that is to some extent user-friendly, the rural participants stated the necessity of training and the ability to enhance interfaces of the applications. Most people believe in mobile banking, but it still does not win the confidence of a significant number of people, mostly in the rural segment. The most popular services are money transfers and payment of bills. These findings are also supported by interview data, which puts an emphasis on the issue of infrastructure and the role of the community support in adoption. The two

insights require rapid development of inclusive digital financial solutions to support the specifications of underserved groups.

5. Discussion of Challenges and Limitations

5.1 Research Limitations

The study was constrained by the fact that the sample size, considered rather small (78 survey participants and 3 interviewees), does not reflect the experiences of the entire Sri Lanka. Also, cross-sectional design does not provide a picture over time; hence, it does not take into consideration seasonal and long-term fluctuations in adoption. There was also a lack of scope to fieldwork due to the lack of time, and even lack of funds, in more rural regions which may have more pronounced digital obstacles.

5.2 Operational and Fieldwork Challenges

Other obstacles to operation were the challenge of accessing the participants in remote rural regions since there was a poor transport system and little internet accessibility. Eventually, a few respondents were not familiar with online surveys, and thus printing was necessary as well as instruction. There were language barriers as well since some were used when addressing older or less educated participants. Arranging interviews was also a tricky task because scheduling of the interviewers and the subjects was a problem, and some of the subjects who were not experienced with formal research lacked enthusiasm. Such challenges necessitated flexibility and variations that would guarantee effective and ethical data collection.

5.3 Validity and Reliability Concerns

Although mixed-methods architecture boosted the depth of data, some elements could have influenced validity and reliability. There may be a social desirability problem in self-reported data whereby some study subjects may exaggerate usage or comfort. Inconsistencies could be caused by the deviations in the interpretation of survey and interview questions. Also, there may be a hindrance to generalizability due to the use of purposive sampling. However, the use of triangulation of survey and interview findings has contributed to increasing the credibility in general and reducing possible biases.

6. Conclusions and Recommendations

6.1 Summary of Key Outcomes

The study identified the strong difference between urban and rural population in mobile banking adoption in Sri Lanka. The users living in the urban areas have higher usage activity, better digital literacy, and mobile banking trust level. Rural users on the other hand are experienced with various barriers such as inaccessibility, low digital literacy and language challenges. Majority of users, however, use mobile banking to help them with such functions as transferring of funds and paying bills. The results can be used to support the notion that localization of digital financial services to the various communities is an excellent strategy.

6.2 Policy and Practical Implications

The results indicate that the policies that encourage digital finance inclusion should address the rural service. Financial organizations and governments are supposed to invest in infrastructure particularly in regions which have ill connectivity. Older and less educated groups should also be taken into consideration and campaigns carried out in local languages. In practice, the mobile banking applications should have an attractive interface and the use of the local languages. Regulatory systems that maintain the privacy of the user and create trust in the digital financial systems should also be put in place by the policymakers.

6.3 Recommendations for Stakeholders

To make services more accessible, banks should also design an easier interface of mobile apps and provide customer service in local languages. To create digital awareness in rural environments, the outreach programs and on-ground training workshops are important. Telecom companies should collaborate to enhance access to the internet in the underserved areas. Schools can collaborate during awareness creations. The government should make strategic partnerships with the people in form of public-private partnership to promote digital infrastructure and financial literacy. The efforts of this type will assist in filling the urban-rural gap in the use of mobile banking.

6.4 Suggestions for Future Research

In future, the adoption of mobile banking on a longitudinal basis using longitudinal studies should be undertaken to monitor behavior change. Generalizability could also be enhanced by a wider, more homogeneous sample that encompasses a bigger sample size in terms of the regions and age categories. It is also possible that further work will be devoted to individual user groups, e.g. women or older citizens, who might have special needs. Also, it should be

considered in future research to assess the efficacy regarding policy implementations and mobile banking capabilities that would address the rural users to give guide on the responses that can be taken by the developers and policymakers.

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Appendices

Appendix A – Survey Questionnaire

Google Survey Questionnaire

Research Title: Adoption of Mobile Banking Services Among Rural and Urban Populations in Sri Lanka

Section 1: Demographics

1. What is your age?

- Under 18
- 18–25
- 26–35

- 36–45
- 46–60
- Over 60

2. What is your gender?

- Male
- Female

3. What is your location?

- Urban
- Rural

Section 2: Mobile Banking Usage

4. how long have you been using mobile banking?

- Less than 6 months
- 6 months to 1 year
- 1–3 years
- More than 3 years

5. Which mobile banking services do you use? (Select all that apply)

- Checking account balance
- Transferring money
- Paying bills
- Mobile recharges
- Loan services
- Other (please specify)

Section 3: Perceptions & Challenges

8. How easy is it for you to use mobile banking apps?

- Very easy

- Somewhat easy
- Neutral
- Somewhat difficult
- Very difficult

9. Have you ever faced any challenges using mobile banking? (Select all that apply)

- Poor internet connectivity
- Lack of knowledge/training
- Language barrier
- Security concerns
- App malfunctions
- No challenges
- Other (please specify)

10. Do you feel mobile banking is secure?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

Appendix B – Interview Questions

1. Can you describe your overall experience with using mobile banking services?
What motivated or discouraged you from starting to use mobile banking?
2. What challenges have you faced while using mobile banking apps or platforms?
3. Do you feel that mobile banking is secure and reliable? Why or why not?
4. What improvements or support do you think would help people in your community use mobile banking more effectively?
5. What improvements or support do you think would help people in your community use mobile banking more effectively?

Appendix – Interview scripts

Participant 1: Urban User (Male, Age 28, IT Professional)

1. Experience:

I have had an experience in mobile banking of more than three years. I am practically using it to check balances, send money, and pay bills. It is easy and timesaving."

2. Motivation/Discouragement:

The reason I did it was due to convenience and time availability. It was also promoted by my bank through advertisement messages and tutorials."

3. Challenges:

Some problems during initial process of the app included freezing of the app during transactions, but this has been addressed in the updates. I have not encountered any serious obstacles.

4. Security Perception:

I have faith in mobile banking. I am confident of the two-factor authentication and app security features."

5. Improvements Suggested:

The user experience could be improved by additional integration of utilities services and immediate customer support represented by a chat.

Participant 2: Rural User (Female, Age 42, Farmer)

1. Experience:

I have been using mobile banking since six months. Mostly I use it to check the balance of accounts and transfer money to my children."

2. Motivation/Discouragement:

I did it at first with fear but my daughter showed me how to use it. Previously, the visits to banks were tiresome and distant, and mobile banking nowadays proves beneficial."

3. Challenges:

There can be cases when the app can fail to load due to bad signal. Moreover, I have a serious problem with the comprehension of certain English terms in the app."

4. Security Perception:

I do not know. Though I am no longer afraid of pressing the wrong button, I fear that someone can steal my information or money.

5. Improvements Suggested:

They could train us more in our local language and simplify the app to people who are aged.

Participant 3: Rural User (Male, Age 36, Small Business Owner)

1. Experience:

I have been performing mobile banking services since several months. I am operating it mainly to transfer money and check incoming payments by customers."

2. Motivation/Discouragement:

It is also a time-saving method considering that the closest bank is more than 10 km away. I heard it through one of my friends, who had an outlet."

3. Challenges:

I experience network glitches quite a lot and the app can simply crash. It gets me mad when I am in a rush."

4. Security Perception:

"I'm cautious. I only use it when I need to do so. I have a wish that the app could have a simpler version that can fit users like me."

5. Improvements Suggested:

The country could use better cell phone reception and a simpler Sinhala variant of the app that would help convince more citizens here to use it.

